DAAT TEVUNOT: THE RAMHAL ON CREATION, GOOD AND EVIL, AND THE SOUL

Does God Forget Anything?

Daat Tevunot §170-171

Sefer: Daat Tevunot by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Sections:** §170 (end; section 9, part 4) and §171 **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's series on Daat Tevunot, Monday 30 October 2023

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Where we are

Page 578, section 9, part 4, the final part of the discussion of mazal. Last time we saw that the two modes, reward and punishment and mazal, work continuously in tandem. When God needs something to happen through mazal for the sake of the tikkun haklali, He dresses it up as reward and punishment, as with Rabbi Yehudah HaNasi's thirteen years of suffering.

§170: every ripple is counted

The Sekhel adds one final point. The fruit of the good deeds of the righteous is mainly stored for the world of retribution, which is eternity. Everything a person does, and every consequence of it, will be compensated, for good and for bad.

When a person does good, it is not only a good deed; it also rectifies something in the world. Part of his reward is for the deed, and part for the effect of the tikkun it brought about. God judges the action itself and also every knock-on effect, according to how much it rectified.

The Rabbi illustrated. You do something good; someone sees it and decides to do the same. That knock-on effect we can see. But think of its influence on others after him, and of the tikkun our actions bring about in the whole system we have discussed. All of it is taken into account. A participant compared it to pushing one thing that pushes another, and the Rabbi agreed: it is a huge, complex system of cogs, and reward or punishment will account for all of it.

Why bother, if we will fall again?

Young people often ask: what is the point of Yom Kippur, if we repent and then go back to the same things? The Rabbi answered with a question. Your suit gets a stain. You take it to the dry cleaner even though in a month it will be dirty again; a parent carrying a baby gets the same stain every time. You still clean it, because if you leave it, the stain sets deeper into the fabric.

The Ramhal makes a related point in the next paragraph: God forgets nothing when He judges. Do not think that if something was damaged and then repaired, He remembers only the repair. He also remembers how bad it was, and how much you rectified. Nor, if something

was rectified and then damaged again, does He remember only the damage. Nothing is forgotten, and there is no end to what a tikkun after destruction is worth.

A participant asked about teshuvah. That, said the Rabbi, is something else. Teshuvah is precisely the power that makes things forgotten. Here we are speaking of the ordinary way things are judged.

Past, present and future

God judges everything according to the whole of the six thousand years: what came before, what is now, and what will come. No action can be taken out of context. Was this thing already rectified before you acted, or already damaged? What did your action contribute, and what came of it afterwards?

A participant asked how that plays out. If something was good and you made it bad, said the Rabbi, that is more serious. If it was already bad, less so. The whole context is part of the judgment.

On the great day of judgment, God will spread out His government before all creation, and we will see how exact His judgment is. Now we cannot see how each action turns all the cogs in the system, but then it will all be clear, and everyone will receive what is commensurate.

"That," said the Rabbi, "is essentially the end of the book." Section 10 is a set of separate topics.

§171: the Neshamah gives thanks

In §171 the Neshamah summarises what it has learned. The Rabbi read it alongside the English notes.

- **God's providence.** I begin to understand His hashgahah, how He runs the world according to the Yihud Hashem, as we saw at the start of the book in sections 2 and 3.
- **Man's work.** I understand what a human being must work on and the effect of that work: perfecting body and soul and their influence on each other. Note 49 recalls section 5 on the origin of evil, man's principal task of removing it, and section 8 on how the service of the righteous perfects the world, the power God gives to the misvot, and our partnership with Him.
- **The reasons for events.** I understand God's judgment; that a world without judgment is worse; His mercy even in punishing; and how mazal works. Note 15 recalls section 7, the five levels of judgment, all stemming from God's love and compassion, section 8 on the sustaining force, and the hidden system of mazal in section 9.
- **Man in different times.** I understand the nature of man in this time and how it will change: the body and the soul before and after Adam's sin, after the resurrection, and the stages beyond the six thousand years (note 51, recalling section 4).
- **The world to come and the resurrection.**

"But most importantly, what you have given me is faith": that everything from Hashem is done with great wisdom, nothing small or large by chance, and that all the cycles of the world lead to the tikkun haklali and the revelation of the Yihud. "You have given me the roots, and the rest I will go and learn."

The Rabbi noted how this answers the student's question at the very beginning, two years earlier: why does everything in the world seem so random?

A cautious thought about the past weeks

He closed carefully. We learned that even a prophet does not know why things happen. But perhaps what we learned about mazal sheds some light. Part of the mode of mazal is the intensification of evil, where innocent people suffer, and the greater the darkness, the greater the Yihud revealed at the end; and at the end of days the darkness and chaos will be more intense than ever. "To see what we've seen, to hear what we've heard," the suffering of innocent children, women and men. "Perhaps, perhaps... this has got to do with the mazal we've talked about." Maybe not; there may be other reasons we do not know. "But that's something to think about."

Next time: a summary of section 9, then the start of section 10.

Summary

- Reward and punishment take account of every knock-on effect of a deed on the whole system of creation.
- God forgets nothing: He weighs both the damage and the repair, as the stain on a suit is cleaned even though it will return.
- Teshuvah is the exception: it is the power that makes things forgotten.
- Every action is judged in the context of past, present and future, and on the great day of judgment the exactness of it will be clear.
- §171: the Neshamah thanks the Sekhel for the principles of the whole book, and above all for settled faith.

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